

Meaning-based Translation in Tiv: Accentuating Accuracy, Clarity, and Naturalness

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Abstract

Translation is an art that, if done correctly, helps to convey the meaning of the source text into the target language in such a way that the target language reader thinks it was not translated but written in his or her language. Such a translation can be said to be accurate, clear and natural. While there are different theories and techniques of translation, this study examines the concept of meaning-based translation, focusing on the importance of accuracy, clarity, and naturalness grounded in Skopos theory of Translation. This theory posits that translation should prioritise conveying the source text's intended function and meaning in the target context. Through a systematic review of existing literature, this research emphasises how meaning-based translation with domestication in view, rather than mechanical translation that tilts towards foreignization, can and should incorporate three indispensable attributes, namely: accuracy, clarity, and naturalness. This research synthesises existing knowledge, providing a comprehensive understanding of meaning-based translation and its applications, thus offering a valuable contribution to the field of Translation Studies.

Keywords: Translation, meaning-based translation, accuracy, clarity, naturalness.

Introduction

Translation is a complex linguistic and cultural process that aims to convey the original message's meaning, intent, and context to the target audience. It is the process of capturing ideas expressed in one language and transplanting them into the minds of people who speak another language. Meaning-based translation, a pivotal approach in translation studies, prioritises the accurate conveyance of meaning over literal or word-for-word translation. This paper explores the significance of accuracy, clarity, and naturalness in meaning-based translation. Also known as functional or communicative translation, meaning-based translation emphasises three core qualities: accuracy, clarity, and naturalness. Accuracy ensures that the translation captures the source text's intended meaning without distortion. Clarity facilitates the ease with which the target audience understands the translated message (that is, it is easy to read and easy to understand), while naturalness maintains linguistic flow, making the translation sound like an original text in the target language and not sounding foreign. By focusing on these principles, meaning-based

translation enhances comprehension and aligns with cultural and contextual nuances, ensuring effective communication across languages. According to Dooga (2005), “Today, translators have become the builders of bridges... between peoples; they establish mutual understanding, transmitting the intellectual riches of one nation to others by the [spoken and] written word. They are the unseen intermediaries by whom thoughts and concepts pass from one person to another.” In line with his position and following the Nigerian government’s language of instruction policy in November 2022, expanding the use of local languages as the language of instruction in all six primary school years, it has become imperative to have translators of existing instructional texts, which are hitherto in English, into Tiv language. The basis for this, according to Adamu (2022), is grounded in “research that has shown pupils learn much better when instruction is in their mother tongue at the primary school level.” On this score alone, there is a lot of work in terms of translation that needs to be done in Tiv language. Couple that with public health messages (e.g., jingles played during Covid-19 pandemic warning the public of certain practices) as well as messages relating to our collective national and international security (e.g., jingles urging citizens to report suspicious elements to security forces) that go out from time to time, the need for accurate, clear and natural translation in Tiv cannot be overemphasized. A pertinent question is: what changes when we translate? The form of the source text may change, but not the meaning. Form, as mentioned here, means the structure used to convey the message. Let us consider an example of how form may change, but not meaning, during translation. In the sentence: **Before he sinned, Adam was a perfect man.** The English sentence employs cataphora, introducing the pronoun “he” before the noun “Adam,” to which the pronoun refers. In Tiv, a mechanical translation will seek to follow such a form (structure), which may have some degree of accuracy (contain all the parts of the original) but not necessarily clear and natural, as in the following: **Cii ve a er isholbyo yô, Adam lu or u voogh.** This structure makes the sentence unnatural and at least slightly ambiguous because it mirrors the source language form. However, in Tiv, when using the third person, the subject is first identified before its pronoun follows later in the sentence. Therefore, a better way to render the sentence above in an accurate, clear and natural way would be: 1. **Cii ve Adam er isholbyo yô, iyange lu or u voogh,** or 2. **Adam iyange lu or u voogh cii ve va er isholbyo ye (Adam was a perfect man before he sinned).** There is clearly a transposition of linguistic units, making for a different form in the target language text, yet the meaning remains the same. Similarly, it would be aberrant to translate **What is your name?** as **Kanyi i lu iti you?, Iti you ér nyi?** or **Iti you kanyi?** The natural way to render that question in Tiv would be: **Iti you ér ana?** (Literally, Your name is who?) This probably stems from the fact that, to the Tiv people, referring to a living person as something is demeaning, so the pronoun “who” is used rather than “what.”

Methodology

In this paper, a mixed-method approach is employed involving descriptive-analytical methods and error analysis. Descriptive-analytical method is used to analyse existing translations in Tiv to evaluate accuracy, clarity and naturalness; while error analysis assesses specific translation errors that affect the accuracy, clarity and naturalness of meaning in Tiv translations.

This study adopts the Skopos theory, introduced by Hans J. Vermeer in the late 1970s. It is a functionalist approach to translation that emphasises the purpose (or “skopos”) of a translation as the guiding principle in the translation process. Unlike traditional equivalence-based approaches, which prioritise fidelity to the source text, skopos theory argues that the target text’s purpose should shape the translation strategy. This approach allows for greater flexibility, acknowledging that translation choices must align with the intended function of the translated text in its specific context (Nord, 1997).

In skopos theory, the translator is seen as an expert with the authority to make decisions that best serve the target audience’s needs. The theory posits that translations may vary widely depending on their intended use, suggesting that a legal text, for instance, may be translated differently if intended for general public understanding versus academic study. The approach advocates for translations that are functionally adequate rather than strictly faithful to the original text (Vermeer, 1989).

Critics of skopos theory argue that it risks downplaying the source text’s cultural and stylistic nuances. However, proponents suggest that this functional orientation reflects real-world translation practices more accurately, especially in contexts like marketing, advertising, and technical translation, where adherence to purpose is paramount (Nord, 2005).

Meaning-based translation is rooted in the functionalist approach (Nord, 1997), which emphasizes the translation’s purpose and the target audience’s needs. This approach is supported by:

1. Semantic Theory: Focuses on meaning representation and inference (Lyons, 1977).

2. Pragmatic Theory: Considers context, implicature, and speaker intention (Grice, 1975).

3. Skopos Theory: Prioritizes the translation's purpose and target audience (Vermeer, 1978).

Review of Related Literature

The concept of meaning-based translation is well captured by Larson (1998) when she says “translation consists of transferring the meaning of the source language into the receptor language. This is done by going from the form of the first language to the form of a second language by way of semantic structure. It is meaning which is being transferred and must be held constant.” Following the same line of thought, Dooga (2005) asserts that “the ultimate goal of most translators and most translation enterprise is to convey the meaning of the source language text into the target language,” adding that “majority of translation projects embarked upon around the world are aimed at reproducing the meaning and intent of the original source language text correctly and completely into the target language, in such a way that it would affect the target language audience the same way as the source text does on its audience.” This agrees with a position taken by Venuti (2000) in referring to translation function as “the potentiality of the translated text to release diverse effects, beginning with the communication of information and the production of a response comparable to the one produced by the foreign text in its own culture.” In a similar conclusion reached by Ianna (2012), he refers to translation as “a branch of comparative linguistics, with a dynamic

dimension and focus upon semantics.” That is the position taken by this study. This study favours domestication, which is incongruous with a view espoused by advocates of foreignization who emphasize maintaining the cultural and linguistic elements of the source text, often to promote cultural diversity and prevent hegemony of target-language norms. One of such proponents is Venuti (1995) who maintained that “a translated text should be the site where a different culture emerges, where a reader gets a glimpse of a cultural other.” This view is supported by Berman (1985), arguing that foreignization respects the “strangeness” of the source language and discourages the erasure of cultural differences. He presents foreignization as an ethical approach that maintains the cultural depth of the source text. According to him, “every translation is a trial of the foreign.” Following in tow, is Baker (2018), who says: “Foreignization is crucial in resisting the assimilative pressures of dominant cultures, allowing minoritised voices to remain distinct.” Shas engaged with foreignization by addressing how translation choices can either erase or highlight cultural specificities. She argues that foreignising approaches allow translations to reflect the complexity of source cultures rather than smoothing them over to fit target-language expectations. Each of these figures contributed to the theoretical foundation of foreignization, emphasising the importance of preserving cultural diversity in translation practices.

Accuracy in Meaning-Based Translation

Accuracy ensures that the translated text conveys the original message’s meaning without distortion or loss. This involves:

1. Semantic Accuracy: Preserving the original meaning, including connotations and implications.
2. Contextual Accuracy: Considering the source text’s historical, cultural, and social context.
3. Conceptual Accuracy: Translating concepts, not just words.

Clarity in Meaning-Based Translation

Clarity guarantees that the translated text communicates the intended meaning effectively, avoiding ambiguity and confusion. This requires:

1. Linguistic Clarity: Using target language norms and conventions.
2. Structural Clarity: Maintaining coherent sentence structure and organisation.
3. Stylistic Clarity: Adapting tone, style, and register to suit the target audience.

Naturalness in Meaning-Based Translation

Naturalness ensures that the translated text sounds authentic and fluent in the target language, avoiding awkwardness or artificiality. This involves:

1. Idiomatic Naturalness: Using target language idioms and expressions.
2. Collocational Naturalness: Preserving typical word combinations.

3. Pragmatic Naturalness: Considering target language pragmatics and implicature.

Foreignization

This is a strategy of retaining information from the source text and involves deliberately breaking the conventions of the target language to preserve its (the source text's) meaning.

Domestication

Domestication is the strategy of making text closely conform to the culture of the language being translated to, which may involve the loss of information from the source text.

Data Presentation and Analysis

Following a mixed-method combining descriptive-analytical approach and error analysis, the following texts demonstrate the value of meaning-based translation with domestication in view.

Descriptive-analytical method

Consider how *Icighan Bibilo* (The Holy Bible in Tiv) accurately, clearly and naturally translates Matthew 28:1. The verse reads in English thus:

1. New International Version (NIV):

“After the Sabbath, at dawn on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary went to look at the tomb.”

2. King James Version (KJV):

“In the end of the sabbath, as it began to dawn toward the first day of the week, came Mary Magdalene and the other Mary to see the sepulchre.”

The point of emphasis here is the adverbial phrase “on the first day of the week” or “toward the first day of the week.” *Icighan Bibilo* renders the verse this way: “Tsô iyange i memen i been kera man sev mbu sôn u aven sha iyange i Lahadi ken Lahadi ngura yô” (After the Sabbath, as it was dawning on Sunday). Why is the rendering “Sunday” better than “the first day of the week”? In the Gregorian calendar used in many parts of the world including Nigeria, the first day of the week is Sunday. However, the first working day is Monday, so many of the target language readers (in this context, Tiv) may not know that the particular day of the week referred to is Sunday. On this note, specificity has made the translation of Matthew 28:1 in *Icighan Bibilo* more natural, clearer and sufficient in accuracy. In English, the first day of the week may not be hard for native speakers to identify, but a good number of Tiv speakers would fumble when asked to identify the first day of the week.

In the book, “*Bearing Thorough Witness About God’s Kingdom*,” published by Watchtower Bible and Tract Society of Pennsylvania, USA, chapter one, paragraph six, line one reads: “To attend an assembly in upper Myanmar, a group of Witnesses made a three-day journey by ferryboat from Mandalay.” The Tiv translation reads:

“Mbashiada mbagenev iyange ve mough ken gar u Mandalay, tar u Myanmar ve nyôr tso ve er zende u kuman ayange atar nahan ve yem mkohol ken vegher tar ugen ken tar la.”

Looking at the translation in Tiv, there is no specific mention of the region “Upper Myanmar” or “ferryboat,” yet it can be said that the translation is accurate and maintains fidelity to the source text. As Dooga (2005) notes, when translating difficult-to-understand terms and sentence constructions, the translator must ask himself these important questions: 1. What *idea* will the translation convey to the audience?

2. How important is it to be specific in this context?

3. Does the translation capture the message, reflecting the intent and the spirit of the source text?

First, we have to realise that the intent or *Skopos* (purpose) of that paragraph is not to offer a lesson in Burmese geography or identify specific means of water transportation in that region of the country, but to emphasise the zeal, determination and effort of the witnesses to attend their religious gathering. In that regard, the translation says they made a three-day journey from the city of Mandalay by boat to attend an assembly in another region of the country. The message is passed, no loss of meaning. The translation technique used here is that of “specific-to-generic.” That is, turning a specific source text reference to a generic one if the specific one will put a strain on the perceptive mechanism of the target readers. And as indicated previously, domestication is the strategy of making text closely conform to the culture of the language being translated to, which may involve the loss of information from the source text. But loss of information here does not mean loss of meaning or the overall message of the text to be translated.

Error Analysis

At times, it is possible to get clarity and naturalness but miss accuracy. Consider the translation of the following verses in Icighan Bibilo: 1. Isaiah 46:10: KJV:

“Declaring the end from the beginning, and from ancient times the things that are not yet done, saying, My counsel shall stand, and I will do all my pleasure.”

NIV:

“I make known the end from the beginning, from ancient times, what is still to come. I say, ‘My purpose will stand, and I will do all that I please.’”

In both King James Version and New International Version, the message from the first part of the verse is that God tells how a matter will end from its beginning. In Icighan Bibilo, this verse is rendered as “M pasen hii sha mhii zan zan mkur” (I make known from the beginning to the end). The translation is clear, unambiguous and natural, yet it is inaccurate as it deviates from the message of the source text. This goes to show the importance of incorporating the three attributes of accuracy, clarity and naturalness in translation. A popular radio station in Makurdi known as Speed FM 98.5 has this catchphrase: Catch Us If You Can. They have asked listeners to translate that and many Tiv speakers have attempted. But their translation lacks

naturalness. The common translation that is heard is “Kôr se wea fatyô yô.” The temptation to start with “Kôr se” (catch us) stems from the influence of the source language on the translator. This translation will be understood because it is accurate. Still it is not framed in the most natural way, which would be to invert the word order to “Wea fatyô yô, kôr se.” To illustrate the unnaturalness of the first structure in Tiv, let us say the following: 1a. “Hide wea fatyô yô.” 1b. “Wea fatyô yô hide.”

2a. “Va wea zua a ian yô.” 2b. “Wea zua a ian yô va.” Any native speaker of Tiv will agree that the sentences 1b and 2b are more natural than 1a and 2a, although both may be understood.

Conclusion

Meaning-based translation in Tiv, with a focus on accuracy, clarity, and naturalness, serves as an essential approach to preserving both linguistic integrity and cultural relevance. By prioritizing the meaning behind words rather than strict literalism, translators can bridge linguistic and cultural divides more effectively, ensuring that the translation resonates authentically with Tiv speakers. This approach not only fosters clearer communication but also enhances the accessibility and relatability of translated content. As translation practices in Tiv continue to evolve, maintaining a commitment to these principles will be vital in delivering translations that honour both the source and target languages, ultimately supporting the growth and preservation of Tiv cultural heritage in an interconnected world.

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